Orange

Joy · creativity · warmth

Orange can recall an apricot, autumn leaves, hot sand and a road worker's vest. One time it feels warming and playful to you, another time loud and too cheerful for how you are feeling. Do you look in it for warmth and the wish to try things, or do you rather need a rest from it?

This page does not tell you what orange means. **It shows it to you from several sides**. How it is mixed, how you paint with it, where its strength comes from, how it is read in different cultures and **what it can awaken in us**.

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How to mix the colour and its shades

In painting, orange is made by mixing yellow and red. **The result, though, depends on the specific colours.** Two different reds with the same yellow can give quite different mixes. A warmer red close to orange is usually easier for a bright mix than a red with a distinctly pink or violet tint. The proportions are approximate, every brand behaves a little differently, so try them out on paper first.

What to prepare

Yellow
Gives a lighter, yellower version of orange.

Red
Pushes it towards vermilion, stronger and redder.

White
Lightens it and creates apricot and peach tones.

Brown
Helps with autumn and earthy shades.

Ochre
Gentler earthy tones, good for pumpkin and clay orange.

Blue
Its opposite on the colour wheel; in a truly small amount it mutes orange.

How can you recognise it without technical names?

A yellower orange may recall a mandarin or a sea buckthorn berry, a redder one a ripe orange or a pumpkin. Names on tubes differ between makers, so put **small samples** side by side and **add white** to part of them. The tint will then show better.

On the tube look for the mark **PO** (Pigment Orange) and a number. It tells you which pigment it is even when the name differs.

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What the additions do



White

Lightens it and shifts it towards apricot and peach. Add it a little at a time.





Yellow

Leads to sunny, mandarin tones.





Red

Leads to vermilion and red-orange. A strong pigment, add it carefully.





Brown

Earthy, autumn tones. Terracotta and rust.





Ochre

Gentler earthy and clay tones, pumpkin.





Blue

Mutes it; a larger dose pulls it towards brown or grey-brown.



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Ten oranges to try

A part can be a drop or an equally large heap of paint. **Take the proportions as a starting point for experimenting**, not as a recipe for a Christmas loaf.

Basic orange



2 parts yellow + 1 part red. Balanced, full of energy.

Yellow-orange



4 parts yellow + 1 part red. Sunny, light, mandarin.

Red-orange



1 part yellow + 2 parts red. Rich, hot, bold. Already approaching red.

Light apricot



1 part orange + 2 parts white, possibly a drop of yellow. Soft and kind. Add the white gradually.

Peach



1 part orange + 4 to 5 parts white, and depending on the result a tiny bit of red. Tender, quiet, warming.

Salmon



4 parts white + 1 part red + roughly half a part yellow. Softly pink, with a light touch of orange.

Pumpkin



2 parts yellow + 1 part red + a tiny trace of ochre. A more earthy form of orange, autumnal.

Terracotta



3 parts orange + 1 part brown; adjust the lightness with white. Earthy, firm, warm.

Muted rust



3 parts red-orange + 1 part brown, possibly a trace of blue. Deep, autumnal.

Soft dusty orange



2 parts orange + 2 parts white + blue on the tip of the brush (roughly 1 part to 20 parts orange). Veiled, soft, a little retro.

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Rainbow – the chakra system

In the usual order of the seven colours orange stands between red and yellow. On the rainbow map of the chakras it is the second and belongs to the sacral chakra. You can imagine it as a place for **experiencing**, **pleasure** and the feeling of **“what delights me”**.

The whole rainbow as a map of questions



Red · root

Safety, support, presence. Ask yourself. Do I have something to lean on? What gives me a sense of safety right now?



Orange · sacral

Experiencing, pleasure, creating. Ask yourself. What does me good? Where do I allow myself joy?



Yellow · solar plexus

Self-worth, will. Ask yourself. What do I want? Where do I need to stand up for myself?



Green · heart

Closeness, relationships. Ask yourself. How am I with myself? Whom do I let close?



Blue · throat

Voice, expression. Ask yourself. What do I need to say? What do I no longer want to swallow?



Indigo · third eye

Inner vision, intuition. Ask yourself. What is beginning to dawn on me?



Violet · crown

Meaning, transcendence, connection. Ask yourself. What gives me meaning? What do I feel connected to?

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Svadhisthana, the sacral chakra

Chakras come from the Indian yoga and tantric tradition. The sacral chakra is called Svadhisthana (in Sanskrit “one's own abode”). It dwells in the area of the lower abdomen. The element of water, the sound syllable **VAM** and a lotus with six petals belong to it. In the classical descriptions the petals are vermilion red.

Its theme is **pleasure**, the senses, **relationships**, creativity and **emotions**. For women this is often translated into questions. Do I allow myself to enjoy things? Can I create without fear of being judged? Can I feel without being ashamed of it? Our sense of guilt can often hold it back.

When the chakra is open. You are allowed to enjoy everything fully. Food, touch, beauty, creating. Your emotions flow. You enjoy relationships and closeness.

When the chakra is closed. You may feel numbness, shame, fear, guilt about pleasure, or on the contrary embarrassment. Or you may chase after joy in vain. **A closed chakra does not mean a bad one.** It is only a signal that perhaps you do not yet allow yourself to enjoy life. That you do not see the possibilities.

How to add orange when you are missing pleasure

- **Wear it**
  An orange scarf, jumper, socks or a piece of jewellery. Something you can keep close to the body.
- **Put it in your home**
  An orange cushion, mug or blanket. Oranges on the table.
- **Eat it**
  Citrus fruit, carrots, pumpkin, apricots. Slowly and with relish.
- **Get creating**
  Orange paint and a brush, with no goal.
- **Fit it into an ordinary day**
  A sunset, a lit candle, orange light.
- **Treat yourself to joy**
  An orange pencil, notebook or a mug that makes you laugh. A small thing just for joy.

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When and how to top up orange when you are missing pleasure in life

When you are running on nothing but experiences and the body already wants rest, you do not need more orange, but something that slows you down.

- **Add blue**
  Its opposite and calm. A blue lamp, blue bedding, water.
- **Add brown**
  Support and stability. Wood, leather, natural fabrics.
- **Mute the orange**
  Replace a rich one with peach or terracotta.
- **Add cream**
  A soft and calm base. Linen, cotton, light bedding.

This is inspiration from tradition, not treatment. Try gently and notice how you actually feel afterwards.

Picture it with an example

For some time now you have simply been “functioning”. You get up, work, take care of what needs doing, and in the evening you tick off another day. Nothing essential has to be falling apart. It is just that something you look forward to has gradually faded out of it.

This is exactly where orange can get its personal meaning, **life is not just something you have to manage**. You can also feel it, taste it and enjoy it.

Next to orange other colours can feel warmer or calmer. Blue cools it, brown grounds it and cream softens it. **These are possibilities of personal reading**, not effects prescribed by a colour combination.

How to use this map

It is a way to sort out the themes you are living through. Do you add orange because you are missing joy and the wish to try things? Or do you take it away because everything is already overflowing? **You choose the meaning.** Both options can be fine. For the second chakra, for example, the classical descriptions tend to mention vermilion red rather than orange.

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Free painting – intuition

When we paint freely, with no goal and no effort to make a pretty picture, **orange** often appears when we want to **warm** something, **bring it to life** or simply **try** something. **The hand reaches for it before the brain manages to call a meeting**. Sometimes we know exactly **why**, other times not at all. **Both are fine**.

What may be hiding behind an orange stroke

The same orange line on paper can mean **something completely different every time** – depending on what is going on in us at the moment. Sometimes it is **joy**, sometimes **restlessness**, sometimes the pure taste of the colour. That is why there is **no point** in reading a painting like a test with **a single correct answer**.

Joy and playfulness.

Spirals, circles, spilled blotches, strokes that go outwards. The paper is full of movement and there is no hurry anywhere.

The wish to create and try things.

Orange next to many other colours, strokes that run off in all directions. Like when ten ideas hit you at once.

Warmth and closeness.

Soft warm areas around the centre, sometimes around something or someone. A colour that snuggles.

Body and sensuality.

Rounded shapes, waves, areas in the lower part of the paper. The tradition I write about below links orange with the lower part of the body and with pleasure.

The need to be seen.

A sharp, firm stroke near the edge, often in a prominent place. Like a hand raised in a crowd.

Autumn and farewell.

Golden and brownish orange, leaves, falling. Something beautiful that is already leaving, or that you fear will leave.

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Orange in a painting. Can it express what is happening inside?

Yes, **it can** – but **it does not have to**. When painting you sometimes reach for a colour before you can name what you feel. Orange can then give form to joy, to ideas, to a longing for warmth and company, but also to autumn wistfulness or a feeling that you have to be cheerful all the time.

Equally it can simply be **a pretty colour** that you happened to have to hand that day. **Meaning** comes only in connection with **your experience**. **The colour itself does not know what happened to you**. You do – or you will work it out in time.

Art therapy also works with the idea that a picture can express something for which words are hard to find. What matters is not a single patch of colour but **the whole picture** and how it came to be. Your situation, memories, the movement of your hand and your feelings while painting.

A predominance of orange alone is **not enough for a verdict** on whether it is joy or the need to be cheerful. Perhaps you were in a good mood. Perhaps you wanted to warm up a cold sheet of paper. And perhaps you simply enjoyed that orange so much that grey had no chance that day.

I want it on the canvas, but I don't dare put it on myself

An orange painting and an orange jumper may ask two completely different things of you. On the **canvas** you give **space to experience**. In clothing you may feel that you are visible and that cheerfulness is expected of you. That is why a large orange area in a painting can attract you while the thought of walking out among people in an orange coat frightens you.

On canvas you can give it enormous space and you do not have to accept at the same time the idea of how you yourself will look in it. **Canvas can be a safe place** where you allow expression in your own way.

Sometimes you want to wear it, sometimes only to paint it. Sometimes you enjoy a pumpkin on the table and would not take an orange jumper even as a tombola prize. That is not contradictory.

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When orange takes over the space

First let it come. Perhaps you reach for orange and have no idea why. Let it appear on the canvas without any duty to explain whether it is joy, longing, anger or a memory of grandmother's apricots. You can paint standing, on the floor, with your hand, a brush or a piece of cloth. What matters is what happens to you when you spread the colour, layer it or let it take up more space.

Three things worth noticing

QUANTITY

A small flame, or the whole summer?

A tiny orange trace can be the centre of the whole painting for you. A large area can feel full, free and warming, or it can start to be too insistent. A large orange area is not proof of great joy, and a small trace does not mean you cannot enjoy life.

SATURATION

Saturated, or gentle?

Pure orange can have the look of a freshly cut orange. With white it turns into a gentler apricot. With ochre or brown it approaches clay, leaves or fired ceramics. If after adding white you are flooded with relief, it is exactly that change that is interesting. Perhaps today a less insistent expression suits you. You do not have to make a conclusion about your whole personality out of it.

THICKNESS

What does it feel like under your hands?

Thick paint you can push, spread and leave a mark in. Thin paint flows and runs and may surprise you with a direction you had not planned. Sometimes you enjoy the substance and resistance, at other times the chance to let go of control and watch what happens. It is not a test of courage. A careful, thin stroke can be exactly your language for today.

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What to take from the picture

It is not about how the orange stroke looks. More important is what you feel while making it, what situation you are in and what is happening in your life right now. Two almost identical paintings can have a completely different story. One was made at a celebration, the other after a week when you had to be cheerful all the time. That is why you will not find a **dictionary** here, but **questions**. **Life will not fit into one colour chart anyway**.

A picture can speak even after time

Perhaps after a while you will notice that you kept returning to orange in a period when you were missing **closeness**, **lightness** or the wish to want something for yourself. Perhaps you will connect it with a completely **different experience**. In self-reflective work inspired by art therapy a painting can serve as a trace of **your own experience** and a chance to look back.

Answers often do not come right away

Sometimes you look at a painting and it tells you nothing at all. And a week, a month or a year later it suddenly comes: “Aha, this is what I was carrying in me then.” That is fine. **The painting is not going anywhere**. You **do not have to** squeeze **an answer** out of it with a still-wet brush.

Neither is wrong and neither is right. Joy, nervousness, the senses and autumn sadness all belong to you, and orange can **carry all of it**.

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Associations and stories

Our associations

Associations are the connections that form between us and a colour. We are not born with a ready-made list “orange = this”, and yet some meanings repeat surprisingly. They are usually made up of three layers: **the body**, **culture** and **what we have lived through ourselves**.

From the body

Orange is the colour of **the setting sun**, **a fire in the hearth** and **citrus fruit**. The eye reads it as **warm** and **near**. After red it is the second warmest and we **associate** it with what warms and feeds. Juicy fruit, heat, the light at the end of the day. Orange says: **Here is warmth and you may come closer**.

From culture

In one country orange is the colour of football fans and celebrations, in another the colour of **protest** or religious **renunciation**, elsewhere again the colour of a prison uniform or a warning vest. One colour can thus handle both **joy** and **warning**. **What we read in it also depends on where we grew up.** We will look at this in more detail in the section on cultures.

From what you have lived

An orange that **smelled of Christmas at grandmother's**, a children's playroom with orange walls, **the setting sun** on holiday, or the orange vest you had to wear at work. These are associations with **your own signature**. **Two women can look at the same orange** and one feels kindness, the other the pressure to be cheerful again. The colour is the same. **The story is not**.

When you know where your associations come from, it is easier to tell what is actually “orange” and what is your story about it. You can ask yourself now. **What comes to mind first when I see a woman in an orange dress or a man in an orange shirt?**

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Stories

A colour named after a fruit

In English it is interesting. The word *orange* first named the fruit and only later the colour. The first recorded use as a colour name is from **1502**, in a record of clothing bought for Margaret Tudor. Before that orange was called “yellow-red”; in Old English there was a word for yellow-red and for saffron-yellow, but not for orange as such. The colour thus got its name from the fruit, not the other way round.

The House of Orange and a country that took on a colour

The County of Orange in southern France was raised to a principality in **1163**. Its name is not related to the fruit. In **1544** the principality was inherited by the eleven-year-old **William the Silent** of the House of Nassau, and from the family came what we know today as the House of Orange-Nassau. According to the usual accounts the family adopted the colour orange in the **1570s**, at the time of the Dutch revolt against Spain. William III later became King of England (1689) and the orange-white-blue flag was a forerunner of today's Dutch tricolour. Orange has remained the colour of the country and of the royal family.

Hermès and the orange box

According to a story the company itself tells, Hermès switched to orange boxes in **1942**. During the war there was not enough of its usual packaging and the supplier offered only orange, “the colour nobody wanted”. Hermès chose it rather than leave the goods without packaging. The colour then became its trademark. **The story comes from the company itself and has not been independently verified.** Still, it is a lovely example of how necessity becomes a brand.

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Emotions and feelings

The same orange can awaken **joy** in one of us and **tension** in another, sometimes even both in one day.

Orange can awaken in us **the wish to create**, **warmth between people** and also **the pressure to be cheerful all the time**. There is no **single fixed effect**. It depends on **our body, experience, culture and situation**.

Emotions

Quick and strong reactions that can appear even before you realise them.

Joy and playfulness

Orange can bring **a feeling of lightness** and **the wish to laugh**. The body relaxes and nothing is so serious at that moment.

And why?

It is linked with **the sun**, **citrus fruit** and **children on a playground**. Orange is a colour that **does not ask performance of us**, only **presence**. It has neither the sharpness of red nor the gravity of dark colours, and so it invites playfulness more easily.

Ask yourself

“When did I last laugh sincerely?”

Enthusiasm and impatience

The wish to **start something right now**. **Energy on the move** that drives you. And when it tips over into **nervousness**, the feeling that **I must keep doing something** and must not stop.

And why?

Orange is close to red, only **gentler**. It encourages and sometimes **pushes**. It is no accident that it is used on vests and warning signs. It is a colour that says “here I am, something is happening”. In the body that can sound like pleasant liveliness, or like a compulsion never to stop.

If I asked you now

“When did you last allow yourself to do nothing?”

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Tenderness and gratitude

A protective, kind feeling towards **people** and towards **a particular moment**. The wish to **touch**, **stroke**, let things be and be grateful for them.

And why?

Orange is **warm and soft**, without the sharpness of red. It recalls **lamplight**, **a warm blanket** and **a palm on the back**. The colour itself does not evoke tenderness or gratitude, but it can open a place for them.

Try asking yourself

"What was I last grateful for?"

Shame and guilt

Right after **a pleasant experience** or **a pleasant thought** a voice sounds: "that's not proper", "you just don't do that". The wish to **hide**, **explain yourself** or **apologise**.

And why?

In tradition orange is linked with the area of **pleasure and the body**. With that comes our upbringing about what is "proper". The colour itself does not evoke shame; rather it **uncovers** it when it touches something we learned to keep on a short leash.

Ask yourself

"Do I sometimes feel guilty about how I feel?"

Feelings and experience

Less immediate than emotions. They say more about how we feel in a situation, in the body and in relation to ourselves.

The wish to create and try things

Orange can awaken **ideas** that run off in all directions and a feeling that **anything can be tried**.

And why?

The link with the **sacral chakra** and creativity is a modern view. Orange is the colour of **beginnings**, not of **perfection**.

A question for you

"What would you like to try now and do not have the courage to?"

Sensuality and relationship to the body

It can bring **pleasure in the body**, an appetite for food, **touch**, beauty. Sometimes a quiet wish to be **at home in your body**.

And why?

This is not a magical property of the colour. Orange is the colour of **ripe fruit**, **warm skin** and **evening light**, and we link those impressions with enjoyment. How you read it is also influenced by what you have learned about what you may allow yourself.

Ask yourself

"When do I feel at home in my body?"

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Sadness and nostalgia

It can evoke **a warming sadness**. A beauty that is already leaving. Memories of warm days that have passed.

And why?

Autumn leaves and **the golden hour**. Orange can hold a farewell so that it is not sharp.

Try asking yourself

"What is drifting away from me and what do I fear?"

A feeling of closeness and openness

It can open a feeling of **closeness** and **openness**. The wish to be **among people**, to eat, chat, share.

And why?

It is linked with **a fire in the hearth** and **a shared meal**. Orange is the colour of **a table you sit around**.

A question for you

"Can you open up?"

My orange is not the same as your orange

The colour itself **experiences nothing**. We experience it. When we first see a colour together with something strong (a smell, a face, a situation, a word), the **experience** sticks to it. The colour then becomes a **shortcut**. One glimpse is enough and the body knows whether it can relax or should pull back. That is why **your own reaction** is the most important.

- **An orange at Christmas**
  For one person the scent of home and childhood, for another a compulsory sweet tradition she is tired of.
- **An orange vest**
  For one safety and visibility, for another work she hates.
- **The setting sun**
  Holiday and calm, or the end of the day when anxiety returns.
- **An orange wall**
  A cheerful room, or a room in which I never wanted to sleep.
- **Halloween and pumpkins**
  Playfulness and celebration, or fear of masks and darkness.

Why does it attract me when I do not actually feel cheerful?

Perhaps it does not express how you feel. Perhaps you are drawn to what you are **missing**. You do not have to be cheerful for a colour you associate with cheerfulness to attract you. After a long period of worries orange can recall ordinary pleasure. Breakfast outdoors, laughter with no explanation, a warm evening or a touch where you do not have to sort anything out. Sometimes you are tired precisely of having lived only sensibly for a long time. And suddenly you like something simply because it is **beautiful, soft or a little bit mad**.

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Why does it seem unpleasant to me, on the contrary?

A strong orange is **too loud** for you. It reminds you of **an old interior**, a school canteen or a setting where you did not feel well. If for a long time you **had to entertain others**, its cheerful look can remind you of a role you no longer want to play. An aversion to orange does not have to mean you reject joy or closeness. Perhaps you are only rejecting another **duty to be pleasant**. Try to tell apart whether you dislike all orange or only a certain form of it. A rust-coloured leaf can be beautiful even though you would not want a glaring orange wall even in a photograph.

When to add it and when to take it away

Add it where it delights you and opens something pleasant. Take it away when you catch yourself **looking away from it**, everything feels too striking or you finally want fewer stimuli. Notice the changes. **Apricot does me good**, bright orange disturbs me. In winter it attracts me more than in the hot summer. In a painting I want it big, in clothes I do not feel good in it yet. These are your specific experiences. They do not have to fit into one answer **“I like orange”**.

If I asked you now

“What does orange in a space evoke in you? Recall whether you have seen orange in a room somewhere at someone's place. How did you feel there?”

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Orange in cultures and traditions

Orange does not have the same **meaning** everywhere. In one country it is the colour of football and celebration, in another of civic protest or the sacred. Let us look at a few places and read them well.

This chapter therefore shows **two levels**. First, how orange is read in different **cultures**, and then how **traditional systems** look at it, using it as an image.

Orange in different cultures

The Netherlands

The colour of national pride, celebration and football. Fans dress in orange, the national team is “Oranje”. At the celebrations of the King's birthday (Koningsdag, 27 April) the whole country wraps itself in orange.

From the House of Orange. The Principality of Orange in southern France (from 1163) was inherited in 1544 by William the Silent of Nassau, later leader of the revolt against Spain. According to the usual accounts the family adopted the colour in the 1570s and it became a symbol of resistance and of the state. The name of the principality was originally unrelated to the fruit.

A colour can become the common language of a whole country when there is a story and a ritual behind it.

India and Buddhist countries

In Hinduism deep saffron (in Sanskrit often called bhagwa) is regarded as one of the most sacred colours and is worn by holy men, the sadhus. Theravada Buddhist monks usually wear a saffron or ochre robe. The saffron stripe on the Indian flag is often interpreted as courage and renunciation.

Buddhist texts specify what colour a monk's robe should be, and the exact shade differs by school and country. Saffron denotes the whole range from yellow-orange to deep orange-red. Tibetan monks, by contrast, wear mainly maroon and yellow.

Orange can be the colour of **renunciation and simplicity**, because it is worn by those who gave up possessions. For them it is the opposite of showing off.

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Ukraine

In 2004 orange became the colour of civic protest and non-violent change. People wore orange scarves, ribbons and flags.

Orange was the colour of Viktor Yushchenko's campaign. The opposing side chose blue, and so the colours became a political label. After the annulment of the election and a repeat vote in December 2004 Yushchenko became president.

A colour can be a tool of **shared identity**. For some it is still a story of hope, for others a political slogan. As everywhere, it depends on who is interpreting it.

Mexico

Traditionally, altars are decorated with marigolds (cempasúchil) at the celebrations of the Day of the Dead. According to tradition the orange and yellow petals show the souls the way home and their scent attracts them.

From indigenous traditions and their connection with Christian feasts. Descriptions differ by region.

Orange can be the colour of **remembering, not of sadness**. It is a warm path between life and memory.

The same colour, opposing stories

In the Netherlands it unites football crowds, in Northern Ireland it recalls division, in India it means renunciation, in Thailand Thursday and in Ukraine hope. **A colour does not have one meaning. It has as many meanings as stories people have learned to attach to it.** If you create for an international audience, or when a colour unexpectedly “does not fit” in a foreign country, it is often not a mistake, just a different story.

Orange in traditional systems

Every tradition looks at orange **a little differently**, but all take it seriously. It is an old symbolic language and a source of inspiration, not a healing guide.

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Traditional Chinese medicine

In Chinese tradition there are five elements. Wood, fire, earth, metal and water. Orange is not among the classical colours of the five elements. **We find it between fire (red) and earth (yellow).** In the so-called generating cycle fire gives birth to earth. Fire turns to ash and from the ash soil is formed.

Earth is the element of the centre, of late summer, of sweet taste, of the spleen and stomach, that is, of digestion. The emotion of earth in the tradition is worry and going round in circles with thoughts. Its strength is that it nourishes.

Orange can be read as a bridge. **The energy of fire that turns into the nourishment of earth.** Joy that becomes what nourishes you. It is not a classical assignment, it is a reading in the spirit of the tradition.

What you can take from it. Ask whether your energy turns into something that nourishes you. If not, the body may feel unsettled, thoughtful, without appetite and with a feeling that you are running all the time. What helps is regular warm food, a calm meal in company and enough rest.

And again you can ask

"What really gives me energy?"

It is not enough only to burn. You also need to be fed

Perhaps you can create a pleasant atmosphere wherever you go. You get the conversation flowing, encourage the others, bring something good. Only then you come home and find that you have again given all your warmth out. In this image two needs meet. **I want to be among people, and I need something pleasant to remain for me too.**

Orange can accompany a moment that not only keeps you busy but also nourishes you. For example a shared meal at which you are not a host in non-stop service. You sit, you eat and the others have brought something too. An apricot tablecloth or a terracotta bowl can support the impression of a warm shared place. What matters, though, is that you really sit at that table too.

When you have little energy

If days blend together, try something pleasant that speaks to the senses. A flower, the scent of a cut orange, your favourite music or a short painting session with no result plan. The benefit can be a moment when you again perceive something with appetite instead of just fulfilling another task. If orange does not speak to you, there is no need to surround yourself with it. What should interest us is the return to experience.

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When, on the contrary, there is too much of everything

Lots of people, noise, duties, colours and social performance. Then another radiant orange can feel like an invitation to a party you have long wanted to leave. Try to put a big rich area out of view. Keep, say, just a muted ceramic or a natural fabric. In personal experience you find out how much liveliness delights you and from what amount it begins to keep you busy.

Ayurveda

Ayurveda is an old Indian teaching about health. It describes a person by three types of "energy", the so-called doshas. Vata (air, restlessness), pitta (fire, intensity) and kapha (earth and water, heaviness). Colours are chosen to balance what there is too much of. Opposites are treated with opposites. Orange is warm, warming and stimulating.

How it relates to the colour orange. According to some sources orange in Ayurveda is read as the colour of warmth and zest for life, linked with the "fire of digestion". **That is why it suits where there is too much cold and heaviness.**

Pitta

This is how a woman is described who is purposeful, quick and thorough, and flares up easily. A rich orange can add fire. The tradition advises cooling and soft colours and orange only in gentle shades.

- **Orange in moderation**
  Peach or light apricot, only as an accent.
- **Add some cool**
  Green, blue and white as a counterbalance.

Vata

This is how a woman is described who is imaginative and quick, but restless, and is often cold. Warm colours generally suit her, but ones that are too garish may increase restlessness. **It is best to notice how you really feel in orange.**

- **Soft warm shades**
  Peach, apricot, terracotta. Warmth without shouting.
- **Evening and sleep**
  Gentle shades and warm light.

Kapha

This is how a woman is described who is calm, steady and patient, but who easily becomes heavy. **Orange warms her up and gets her moving.** The tradition advises warm and lively colours, for instance orange, yellow and red.

- **Add orange**
  A jumper, scarf, cushion, citrus fruit on the table.
- **Add movement**
  A walk, dancing, a brisker pace.

An online test will not reliably determine your dosha. If you are more interested, consult a qualified Ayurvedic practitioner. It is not treatment.

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A Jungian view

Carl Gustav Jung, the Swiss psychiatrist, understood colours as symbols that have two layers. A personal one (what we have experienced with the colour) and one shared by all people (images that repeat across ages and cultures).

In lectures at ETH in Zurich he linked colours with the functions of the psyche. Red with feeling, blue with thinking, green with the senses and yellow with intuition. **Jung did not describe orange as a separate function.** What I write next is my own reflection in the same spirit, not a statement by Jung.

How it relates to the colour orange. Orange is a blend of red and yellow, that is, of feeling and intuition. **It could be the colour of the moment when feeling and idea meet and the wish to act arises.** For Jung it was important that opposites do not have to exclude each other.

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Feng shui

Feng shui is the Chinese art of arranging a space so that it is good to live in. Orange is not a separate element in the classical list of the five elements. According to many authors it belongs to the element of **earth** (together with yellow, brown and beige), and some link it also with **fire**. **Sources differ.**

In the map of the house called the bagua, the centre, the northeast and the southwest belong to earth. The southwest is linked with relationships and partnership. In a home orange is therefore often the colour of **warmth**, **nourishment** and **sociability**.

Orange is like turmeric

A little colours and warms a whole dish, a handful turns it into an experience that you then have on your fingers and on the tablecloth.

In feng shui orange therefore often works best as an **accent**. A cushion, lamp, ceramics, a painting or a detail on a textile adds warmth to a space. An orange wall, carpet and curtains all at once can already feel like a room that keeps inviting you to a party.

Simple tips

- **Want more warmth?**
  Add one orange piece where you will see it every day.
- **Want more calm?**
  Choose peach, apricot or terracotta and leave the rich one just for a detail.
- **Is it already too much?**
  Add wood, linen, cream, blue or more free space.
- **Want more playfulness?**
  Take an orange crayon or a notebook and plan nothing with it.

And above all. Before you repaint a whole room, try **a throw**, **a fabric** or a larger colour **sample**. Your feeling is more important than the rules.

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What people say and what holds true

MYTH Orange is garish and does not belong in a home.

TRUTH A rich neon really does shout. But apricot, peach and terracotta are soft and warming. Start with a cushion or ceramics.

MYTH Orange adds energy.

TRUTH For some people yes, especially in the morning and among people. A rich orange in the bedroom in the evening may rather stir you up. Notice when it does you good.

MYTH The more orange, the more cheerful.

TRUTH Orange is like turmeric. A little warms, a handful overpowers everything else.

What orange works well with

- **Cream and linen**
  A softer whole in which orange does not have to shout.
- **Wood and clay**
  A more earthy, lived-in impression.
- **Blue**
  A striking warm and cool contrast; try which one will be the main one.
- **Green**
  It can recall a garden, leaves and fruit. Watch the richness of both colours.
- **Black**
  A strong contrast. If you do not want an impression of Halloween or sports kit, try only a little of it.
- **Grey and white**
  A cleaner, calmer impression. Orange easily stands out against them.

When you say colours “clash energetically”, you can start concretely. Are both too rich? Are there too many of them? Is their proportion not right for me? Change one thing and try spending some time in the room. Not just looking at it from the corridor.

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Elements

In feng shui the elements are related to one another.

- **Fire creates earth**
  Terracotta, clay and brown tones calm and ground orange.
- **Wood feeds fire**
  A plant and an orange picture can feel alive and growing.
- **Water dampens fire**
  Symbolically blue and very dark blue belong here, the opposite of orange.
- **Earth supports metal**
  White, grey and metal add restraint to orange.

Take it as a **traditional image** of the relationships between elements, **not as a ban** on combining two colours in one room. Feng shui has several schools and the recommendations differ.

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Feng shui room by room

What works – what to watch for – a simple tip.

Living room

What works. Orange accessories. **Cushions**, **lamps**, **blankets**. A social place needs warmth. If the living room is grey and nobody much wants to sit in it, try an apricot or terracotta throw, a picture or a cushion next to wood and a light fabric.

What to watch for. If you have a striking sofa, a patterned carpet and several coloured decorations, further orange can make the impression **too dense**. The sofa does not have to compete with the television for the lead role.

A simple tip. Wool, linen and ceramics in apricot or terracotta **warm without shouting**. Glossy rich surfaces make noise in a room. Where in the room is it good to look from and where is it good to sit?

Kitchen and dining room

What works. Terracotta, apricot, warm wood. **Matt ceramics**, wood and a linen tablecloth in orange invite you to the table.

What to watch for. In a small hot kitchen with a glossy red worktop I would not add a large rich orange area. If a room already feels fiery, it may be more pleasant with **a light, matt and more restrained companion**.

A simple tip. Orange can accompany hospitality and gathering. The point is not to guarantee a bigger appetite, but to create a place where you want to **sit down**. A glossy orange worktop sounds louder than a mug on a shelf.

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Bedroom

What works. Orange in a small dose and in soft shades. Cotton and linen in peach or apricot are soft to look at and to touch.

What to watch for. First try a radiant orange across a whole room in a larger sample, also in the evening. If its look keeps you busy, reduce the area or move it **out of view from the bed**. A rich shine is less suited to falling asleep.

Peach is sometimes said to bring tenderness and a little romantic restlessness. In some interpretations of feng shui there is a link with “peach blossom luck”, that is, the theme of attraction and love life. Take it as a symbolic interpretation, not a prediction. A peach throw has no dating profile of its own. A more interesting question. What form of closeness do I want to live in my bedroom? Tenderness, playfulness, sensuality, or right now mainly calm and privacy?

A simple tip. A colour alone will not arrange sleep or passion. But it can belong to an environment in which you feel good. What do you see just before falling asleep and how does it feel to look at it?

Children's room

What works. Playful accents yes. Orange can be nice in a play corner, on a storage box or in a picture. Children like to touch colour too.

What to watch for. Whole walls, a bed, curtains and a carpet all in rich orange may suddenly be too stimulating. A child may have a livelier environment around play and a calmer view around the bed.

A simple tip. Orange storage boxes, a small rug or a cushion are playful and can be moved. When a room feels overcrowded, first try removing patterns and striking surfaces. Also take an interest in what is pleasant for the particular child.

Study and studio

What works. Soft orange for creativity. One orange picture or area by a place for ideas can be a pleasant lift.

What to watch for. A rich one can disturb concentration. When every object leads you away from work, leave orange out of the main view.

A simple tip. One orange thing on wood or paper adds a spark. Orange can be a great companion. I would rather not entrust it with the role of leading all your tasks in progress. From where is it pleasant to see into the room?

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Hallway and bathroom

What works. In the hall a smaller orange picture or a terracotta bench. In the bathroom an apricot towel or ceramics in a warm shade.

What to watch for. A narrow dark corridor can bear less rich orange than a light open space.

A simple tip. Ask yourself. Does the space **welcome me**, or does it shout at me right on arrival?

Ask yourself

"Why do I want orange at home? What is it meant to bring me. Warmth, playfulness, appetite?"

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Colour frequency and phototherapy

Muted amber or orange light can recall **a candle**, **a fire** or **the evening sun**. It can create a more intimate atmosphere than a brightly lit room. Let us say which of that is **atmosphere** and which is already **treatment**.

And this is exactly where it is good to put **miraculous promises** aside. Orange light is **not a magic lamp** for hormones, mood or chakras.

Why orange light can be pleasant in the evening

Warm orange light contains little of the blue component and tends to be softer than cool white. In the evening it is easy to slow down in it. Less glare, gentler contrasts. For an evening routine, though, it is not only the shade that matters. It also depends on the **brightness**, the length of time the light is on and how much light falls into the eyes. A very bright orange lamp right in front of your face is not automatically more suitable than a weak warm light out of direct view.

What you can try at home

In the evening switch off the large ceiling light and leave a smaller lamp on with a warm, muted light. So that you can see well and do not have to strain your eyes. **What it can bring you.** Less glare and an environment in which it is easier to move from activity to a calmer evening. During the day, on the other hand, do not shut yourself into an orange half-light with the idea that it is beneficial in all circumstances. Daylight and evening quiet have different places in an ordinary day.

Where light is really studied

Blue-light glasses

Glasses that filter blue light (sometimes amber-tinted) are often offered, promising better sleep or less eye strain. A **2023 Cochrane review** summarising 17 randomised trials, however, concluded that the evidence is **inconclusive**. For eye strain from computers there seems to be no short-term benefit, for sleep the effect is unclear. The studies did not assess long-term effects on the retina.

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Skin

In dermatology LEDs of various colours are used. Most data exist for **red** and **near-infrared** light. Yellow light around **590 nm** (sometimes called amber) penetrates the skin only about 0.5 to 2 millimetres and is studied mainly in skin ageing and as an adjunct after laser procedures. An older review from 2015, however, summarises rather small studies and **inconsistent** results. So not even these show that a home orange lamp would improve the skin.

Seasonal depression

For some difficulties light therapy is genuinely used, for example **bright white light** for seasonal depression. The choice of approach is guided by the specific problem, not by a favourite colour, and belongs in the hands of a doctor.

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Astrotype and colours

Are you Gemini, Leo, Sagittarius or another sign? The astrotype is **a much broader topic** than just the sun sign. If you really want to go into depth, knowing only your date of birth is not enough. The exact place and time of birth are also important, because only from them are the ascendant, the position of the Moon, planets and other parts of the horoscope calculated. Here, though, we stay only at the edge of what relates to colours.

The ascendant is the sign that was rising on the eastern horizon at the moment of your birth. According to astrological tradition it shows how you come across outwardly and how you enter the world, while the Sun sign describes more who you are inside. For each sign you will therefore find not only its character but also a short note on how the colour fits when it is your ascendant.

Aries (21 March – 19 April)

Your orange

Bright orange · vermilion · mandarin

An orange that has drive but does not shout the way scarlet does.

Aries is linked in astrology with **Mars**, fire and the start of spring. Orange is for it the softer sister of red. It gives you **courage without needless sharpness**.

What Aries is like according to astrological tradition

Element fire · quality cardinal · ruler Mars

Aries opens the zodiac and you can tell that it is first. It is a **pioneer** who gets into things before thinking them through perfectly. It is direct, impatient and likes to compete. It gets angry quickly but forgives quickly too.

Its strength is the **courage** to begin. Weaker is perseverance in long, slow matters. It does best where something is happening and where it can act at once.

What it can support in you

Orange can support the wish to **begin** without your having to charge off shouting. It suits moments when you want energy but do not want to collide with things needlessly.

With Aries the strength tends to lie in not standing still for long. Orange keeps it company in that.

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Shadow giving energy away to everything

In the shadow Aries gets excited about everything at once. It promises, sets things going, and then tiredness comes, because joy has turned into a race.

Aries does not like delay. Orange may feel to you like **slowing down**, because it is softer than your red.

And if you take it too hastily, you add gas where things are already going fast enough. Impatience, “still today” and ten things in progress.

The colour can also help you here. It helps you get excited and take **joy** in it, not just performance.

Counterbalance what to balance it with

When orange feels not sharp enough to you, add **Mars red** as an accent. When there is too much of it, this helps.

- Mars red as an accent
- cream
- light blue

Cream and light blue slow the pace without taking away your warmth.

Aries as ascendant

When Aries is your ascendant, you come across as direct, lively and decisive. People may see you as someone who gets straight to the point, and the first impression tends to be brisk.

Orange softens your impression, it is energy without sharp edges.

In everyday life

*Keep orange for moments when you want **energy without kicking the door in**. A scarf, a mug, one piece of furniture.*

When you get carried away, try peach. It will remind you that a start can be warm too.

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Taurus (20 April – 20 May)

Your orange

Terracotta · dusty orange · clay · pumpkin

An orange you can feel with your hands. Clay, wood, ceramics.

Taurus is an **earth sign** linked with Venus, the senses and stability. Orange gives it **warmth and relish**, for example in food, wood and ceramics.

What Taurus is like according to astrological tradition

Element earth · quality fixed · ruler Venus

Taurus is an earthy, **patient** and sensual sign. It likes good food, pleasant materials, nature and security. It gets going slowly, but once it decides on something, it persists.

Its strength is **reliability** and the ability to enjoy the present moment. The weaker side tends to be stubbornness and finding it hard to let go of what is familiar.

What it can support in you

Orange can support **sensuality**, the wish to enjoy the moment and contact with the body.

With Taurus it is often not only about the colour but about the material. Orange on a bowl of fired clay or on a linen tablecloth feels entirely different from glossy plastic.

Shadow comfort and consolation through food

In the shadow the pleasant turns into a refuge. Taurus stays with what warms and puts off the change it has long felt coming.

Taurus needs **tangibility**. A rich, loud orange may feel to you like needless noise if you like calm and certainty.

And once you have got used to something, you do not want to let go of anything you know. Warm, heavy and dense colours may further support the feeling that nothing is moving.

The colour can also help you here. It helps you enjoy food, company and **comfort** without guilt.

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Counterbalance what to balance it with

Venus green or pink and something light.

Soft green · pink · cream · light wood

They add more lightness and freshness.

Taurus as ascendant

When Taurus is your ascendant, you come across as calm, stable and pleasant. You build trust slowly and people often feel firm ground in you.

An earthy orange, for example terracotta or apricot, gives comfort and zest for life.

In everyday life

Orange may remind you that pleasure ***is not a reward for performance****.*

You can have something nice without having to earn it first with three completed tasks.

Gemini (21 May – 20 June)

Your orange

Mandarin · bright orange · coral

A playful orange that does not stay long in one place.

Gemini is linked with **Mercury**, movement and curiosity. According to one source (digitalambler) orange, playful and imaginative, is among Mercury's colours too.

What Gemini is like according to astrological tradition

Element air · quality mutable · ruler Mercury

Gemini is **curious**, talkative and adaptable. It learns quickly, likes to tell stories and enjoys it when a lot is going on around it. It can see several sides of one thing.

Its strength is **lightness** and wit. The weaker side tends to be scatteredness and a tendency to start more things than can be finished.

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What it can support in you

Orange can add **a spark**, the wish to **talk**, **try things** and **react**.

When you are bored, it can wake you up quickly. And Gemini really cannot be bored for long.

Shadow flitting from one amusement to another

In the shadow Gemini runs from one pleasure to the next. It creates and has fun, but does not bring anything to an end.

Gemini gets bored quickly. **Orange alone** may feel monotonous to you and then you swap it for another colour before you can finish.

Too many ideas and colours at once can end with an unfinished diary, an unfinished painting and five books started.

The colour can also help you here. It helps you **create**, tell stories and have fun without pressure for a result.

Counterbalance what to balance it with

Mercury blue brings room to breathe.

Mercury blue · light blue · white

White and blue tidy up attention without switching off the play.

Gemini as ascendant

When Gemini is your ascendant, you come across as lively, friendly and chatty. People may see you as curious and youthful, even if inside you are perhaps calmer.

Orange underlines it, whether it is a playful detail or a whole outfit.

In everyday life

*Put orange where **playfulness and conversation** fit. A table for guests, a notebook, a mug.*

For days when your head is racing choose a gentler shade and leave just one orange detail.

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Cancer (21 June – 22 July)

Your orange

Apricot · peach · salmon

A soft orange that warms and does not speak loudly.

Cancer is linked with the **Moon**, water and the start of summer. It is caring and sensitive. Soft apricot and peach **nourish and warm**.

What Cancer is like according to astrological tradition

Element water · quality cardinal · ruler Moon

Cancer is **caring**, sensitive and strongly connected to home and family. It has a good memory for feelings and relationships. It enters the world cautiously, much like a crab with its shell.

Its strength is **empathy** and the ability to create safety. The weaker side tends to be changeable moods and a tendency to withdraw when it feels hurt.

What it can support in you

Orange can support a feeling of **home**, the wish to care and be close.

With Cancer it is important that the colour is not “public”. Orange suits it on a blanket, a mug and lamplight.

Shadow giving yourself away to others

In the shadow Cancer cooks, comforts and cares until nothing is left for it. The need for closeness turns into a fear that without caring it will not be loved.

Cancer is vulnerable. **An orange that is too rich** can strengthen irritation and the feeling that there is too much of everything.

And when you are already caring for everyone, another warming colour may remind you that it is you who keeps warming.

The colour can also help you here. It helps you open up and enjoy closeness, **warmth** without worry.

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Counterbalance what to balance it with

Moon white and silver bring calm back.

Moon white · silver · light blue

They add coolness and softness so that the warmth does not overflow.

Cancer as ascendant

When Cancer is your ascendant, you come across as gentle and careful. At first you keep your distance, but then warmth unfolds and people see in you someone who will look after them.

A peach or apricot orange looks like the warmth of home.

In everyday life

*Orange in **a soft fabric** and in **evening light** is safest for you.*

Give yourself something warming just for yourself, not only for others.

Leo (23 July – 22 August)

Your orange

Golden orange · amber · bright orange

An orange that shines, but with dignity.

Leo is linked with the **Sun**, fire and the peak of summer. Orange is close to the golden colour of the Sun and gives you **dignified joy**.

What Leo is like according to astrological tradition

Element fire · quality fixed · ruler Sun

Leo is **generous**, proud and creative. It likes to give, likes to rejoice and needs others to see and appreciate it. It is loyal and has a big heart.

Its strength is **warmth** and the ability to inspire others. The weaker side tends to be sensitivity to criticism and a tendency to want to be the centre of attention.

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What it can support in you

Orange can support **self-confidence** and the wish to be seen in your place.

Leo wants to shine. A golden orange gives it a reason to, without its having to raise its voice.

Shadow showing off and the need for applause

In the shadow Leo rejoices only when someone sees it. Creativity serves recognition and silence without an audience hurts.

Leo does not want to go unnoticed. If orange is too garish, it can look like an effort **to impress at all costs**.

And when you want everyone to see you, it can tire you that everyone sees you.

The colour can also help you here. It helps you share your **creativity** and your joy in the people around you.

Counterbalance what to balance it with

Sun gold and yellow hold the Sun.

Sun gold · light yellow · dark red

A soft gold is more dignified than a rich and garish one.

Leo as ascendant

When Leo is your ascendant, you come across as self-assured, warm and striking. You enter a room in a way that people notice you even when you do not want them to.

Orange with gold is a natural complement, just do not let it shout louder than you.

In everyday life

*Orange suits **moments when something has gone well for you**.*

When it becomes a uniform, try swapping it for something calmer for a day.

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Virgo (23 August – 22 September)

Your orange

Apricot · peach · dusty orange

An orange that loosens order but does not upset it.

Virgo is linked with **Mercury**, earth and the end of summer. According to the same source Mercury can have orange tones. **Playfulness that loosens order**.

What Virgo is like according to astrological tradition

Element earth · quality mutable · ruler Mercury

Virgo is **meticulous**, attentive and practical. It notices details that others overlook and likes to be useful. It tends to be modest and judges itself more strictly than others.

Its strength is **reliability** and the ability to improve things. The weaker side tends to be perfectionism, worries and a tendency to criticise itself.

What it can support in you

Orange can support **playfulness and lightness** where you otherwise watch the detail.

It works well in a small dose. A cushion, a mug, one coloured detail in a light room.

Shadow joy as another task

In the shadow Virgo plans even rest. Pleasure has to be useful and correct, and so it cannot be lived.

Virgo is critical, above all of itself. Orange may feel **chaotic** and distracting to you.

And when you are strict with yourself, even a cheerful colour can start to serve as another item on the list.

The colour can also help you here. It helps you loosen up and bring **playfulness** back into life.

Counterbalance what to balance it with

Blue or white brings clarity.

Mercury blue · white · light grey

Clean surfaces make room so that orange does not feel like clutter.

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Virgo as ascendant

When Virgo is your ascendant, you come across as neat, restrained and reliable. People see you as observant and sensible, sometimes even overly reserved.

A muted orange, such as cinnamon or brick, adds warmth without eccentricity.

In everyday life

Orange may remind you that done does not have to be perfect.

*Try it on things that **do not have to be useful**.*

Libra (23 September – 22 October)

Your orange

Peach · apricot · salmon

A pastel orange with charm.

Libra is linked with **Venus**, air and the start of autumn. It seeks balance and beauty, and so orange in **pastel shades** suits it.

What Libra is like according to astrological tradition

Element air · quality cardinal · ruler Venus

Libra longs for **harmony**, beauty and justice. It is diplomatic, sociable and has a feel for aesthetics. It lives best in relationships in which it does not feel alone.

Its strength is **tact** and the ability to see both sides. The weaker side tends to be hesitation and a tendency to avoid conflict even when it would help.

What it can support in you

Orange can add **charm and lightness**. Next to cream or light green it becomes an elegant accessory.

Libra has a feeling for proportions. It knows how much orange still adorns.

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Shadow pleasantness at any price

In the shadow Libra keeps up a good mood even when it disagrees inside. Sociability covers what it would like to say.

Libra finds it hard to decide. A rich orange may feel **too loud** to you and make deciding even harder.

And when you cannot determine which shade of orange is the right one, what may remain from the choosing is tiredness rather than joy.

The colour can also help you here. It helps you build relationships and share **joy**.

Counterbalance what to balance it with

Venus green, pink or white keep the balance.

Venus green · pink · white

Soft colours around it leave it its charm without drama.

Libra as ascendant

When Libra is your ascendant, you come across as elegant, pleasant and balanced. People like you for your tact, even if inside you take a long time to decide.

Orange in gentle shades adds social lightness.

In everyday life

*Choose **one shade** and live with it for a week. A decision is sometimes born only when we live with a colour for a while, breathe, create.*

Put orange where you will look at beauty. A vase, a tablecloth, a scarf.

Scorpio (23 October – 21 November)

Your orange

Rust · brick · cinnamon · terracotta

A burnt orange with depth, like brick or cinnamon.

Scorpio is in tradition linked with **Mars**, water and autumn. It likes depth and intensity, which is why its orange is **muted and burnt**.

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What Scorpio is like according to astrological tradition

Element water · quality fixed · ruler Mars, in the newer view also Pluto

Scorpio is **intense**, deep and loyal. It feels strongly, but does not always show it. It dislikes superficiality and likes to get to what is hidden.

Its strength is **determination** and the ability to transform. The weaker side tends to be distrust, jealousy and a need to keep things under control.

What it can support in you

Orange can support **inner heat** without an outer show.

With Scorpio it is about the feeling that the colour knows something and does not need to talk about it.

Shadow a cheerful mask

In the shadow Scorpio hides depth behind lightness, or on the contrary rejects joy as superficial. Both are a distance from what it really feels.

Scorpio cannot stand superficiality. **A cheerful rich orange** may feel superficial to you.

And a deep colour easily turns dark when something is troubling you. Then try not to add another heavy layer.

The colour can also help you here. It helps you release tension and open up to **lightness**.

Counterbalance what to balance it with

Mars dark red suits a muted orange. When you need light.

Mars dark red · cream · olive

Cream and olive let air into the depth.

Scorpio as ascendant

When Scorpio is your ascendant, you come across as focused, mysterious and strong. People sense the intensity of your gaze and often feel that you know more than you say.

A deep orange, such as caramel or mustard, suits it; a radiant orange is more of a lightening.

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In everyday life

*Orange suits **a deep earthy form**. Ceramics, wood, wool.*

Treat yourself to one cheerful thing that does not have to be deep.

Sagittarius (22 November – 21 December)

Your orange

Amber · bright orange · saffron

The orange of journeys, sunsets and enthusiasm.

Sagittarius is linked with **Jupiter**, fire and late autumn. It loves freedom and travel. Orange is the colour of **the sunset** and **enthusiasm**.

What Sagittarius is like according to astrological tradition

Element fire · quality mutable · ruler Jupiter

Sagittarius is **optimistic**, open and free-spirited. It loves travel, new experiences and the search for meaning. It speaks honestly, sometimes a little too directly.

Its strength is **enthusiasm** and faith in a good outcome. The weaker side tends to be impatience with detail and a tendency to promise more than can be managed.

What it can support in you

Orange can support **the wish to set out** and look further.

Sagittarius will carry it on a scarf, a rucksack or a map.

Shadow promising and not keeping up

In the shadow Sagittarius promises enthusiastically and then cannot keep up. Adventure turns into an escape from the everyday.

Sagittarius hates restrictions. **Too much orange** may feel like a cage to you if you have no movement in it.

And optimism can turn into “it will somehow work out”.

The colour can also help you here. It helps you **rejoice** in the journey and in discovery.

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Counterbalance what to balance it with

Jupiter blue or green gives distance.

Jupiter blue · green · white

Blue and green add a horizon.

Sagittarius as ascendant

When Sagittarius is your ascendant, you come across as open, jovial and adventurous. People see you as someone with a wide outlook and an appetite for discovery.

Orange is its natural ally and adds enthusiasm.

In everyday life

*Orange may remind you that **the journey is also at home**.*

Sit for a while at sunset and do not think about the next destination.

Capricorn (22 December – 19 January)

Your orange

Burnt orange · terracotta · clay

Warmth without distraction. Terracotta and fired clay.

Capricorn is linked with **Saturn**, earth and winter. It is practical and persevering. Burnt orange and terracotta give it **warmth without distraction**.

What Capricorn is like according to astrological tradition

Element earth · quality cardinal · ruler Saturn

Capricorn is **responsible**, goal-oriented and disciplined. It likes to build and is not afraid of a long road. It has a dry sense of humour and shows it only to those it trusts.

Its strength is **perseverance** and the ability to see things through. The weaker side tends to be strictness with itself, reserve and a tendency to put joy off until later.

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What it can support in you

Orange can support **a feeling of warmth** in the middle of structure and deadlines.

It carries it well on materials that last. Ceramics, wood, leather.

Shadow joy as a reward for work

In the shadow Capricorn allows itself pleasure only after the work is done. And because work never ends, joy does not come.

Capricorn is strict with itself. **A bright orange** may disturb your calm and order.

And when you endure for a long time, you may forget that warmth belongs to you too.

The colour can also help you here. It helps you allow yourself **rest** and joy without work beforehand.

Counterbalance what to balance it with

Something **just for joy**.

Cream · olive · brown

Soft materials and a warm colour that does not have to achieve anything.

Capricorn as ascendant

When Capricorn is your ascendant, you come across as serious, mature and reserved. People may see you as older than you are, and only later discover how funny you are.

A muted orange, such as rust or brick, adds warmth and softens distance.

In everyday life

*Take orange into **winter**, as a lamp or a blanket.*

Treat yourself to something with no purpose and no result.

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Aquarius (20 January – 18 February)

Your orange

Unusual orange · vermilion · with turquoise

Orange as an unexpected accent.

Aquarius is in tradition linked with **Saturn**, air and winter. It likes distance and independence. Orange is for it **an unusual accent** that is worn well.

What Aquarius is like according to astrological tradition

Element air · quality fixed · ruler Saturn, in the newer view also Uranus

Aquarius is **independent**, original and idealistic. It is interested in ideas, humanity and the future. It wants to go its own way and does not like adapting to expectations.

Its strength is **perspective** and the ability to come up with new things. The weaker side tends to be distance from feelings and a tendency to withdraw when there is too much closeness.

What it can support in you

Orange can support **originality**. One coloured piece in an otherwise calm wardrobe.

It suits where you do not want to blend in.

Shadow distance behind humour

In the shadow Aquarius jokes and withdraws. Lightness serves as a shield against closeness.

Aquarius does not like predictability. As a main colour orange may feel **too obviously cheerful** to you.

And if the colour starts to carry you into the role of “the one who brings energy”, your own peculiarity may slip away from you.

The colour can also help you here. It helps you get closer to people and let yourself be **inspired**.

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Counterbalance what to balance it with

One unexpected colour accent.

Turquoise · grey · indigo

A cool counterpart underlines that orange is your choice, not a duty.

Aquarius as ascendant

When Aquarius is your ascendant, you come across as independent, a little unusual and friendly. People see you as an original personality who keeps their own space.

Orange in a surprising combination, for example with turquoise, looks fresh.

In everyday life

*Orange on **a single object** (a lamp, socks, an envelope) works better than a whole outfit.*

Try it in a place where nobody expects it.

Pisces (19 February – 20 March)

Your orange

Light apricot · peach · dusty

Apricot like a sunset over water.

Pisces is in tradition linked with **Jupiter**, water and the end of winter. They love dreams and gentleness. Light apricot shades are like **a sunset over water**.

What Pisces is like according to astrological tradition

Element water · quality mutable · ruler Jupiter, in the newer view also Neptune

Pisces is **empathic**, intuitive and dreamy. It picks up the moods around it and often has a rich imagination. It frequently has a bond with art, music and spirituality.

Its strength is **compassion** and creative fantasy. The weaker side tends to be merging with other people's feelings, escaping into dreams and difficulty setting boundaries.

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What it can support in you

Orange can support **dreaming** and quiet consolation.

It is best carried by soft, bleeding surfaces.

Shadow dreaming instead of experiencing

In the shadow Pisces imagine beautiful moments and leave them in imagination. Or they are swallowed by the mood of the group and lose their own appetite.

Pisces easily dissolve. **A sharp orange** can jolt you out of your inner world.

And when you escape into dreaming, another warm colour will not help you back into the world.

The colour can also help you here. It helps you carry dreams into **creativity** and connect with people.

Counterbalance what to balance it with

Jupiter blue and green, soft shades of water.

Jupiter blue · green · light blue

Water calms and grounds.

Pisces as ascendant

When Pisces is your ascendant, you come across as gentle, dreamy and adaptable. People like to project their wishes onto you and tend to be kind to you.

Peach or coral softens the impression, a rich orange overpowers it.

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In everyday life

*Apricot can remind you that **gentleness is strength**.*

When the day dissolves for you, do one small thing with your hands.

FOR A DEEPER LOOK

- **Seasons**

Orange is the colour of autumn. Leaves, pumpkins, sunset. Leo belongs to summer and Sagittarius to autumn. Ask yourself when you reach for orange.

- **Time of day**

Orange is the colour of sunset and evening light. In the morning it can be too loud, in the evening it warms.

- **Years of life**

Saturn returns to the place where it stood at your birth at roughly 27 to 31 years of age and again between 56 and 60. Astrology reads it as a time of re-evaluation and new order. In those years orange may feel close to you, or on the contrary foreign. Both are natural.

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Colour for your website and business

Yes – but more as a friendly spark than as the main voice.

In business orange is red's friendly sister. It is **warm** and **energetic**, but it does not command. **It invites you closer.** At the same time it is the colour that shouts “watch out” on the road. That is why it is good to know what you are promising before you let it into a logo, a website or an advert.

By itself, though, it **does not attract customers** like a magnet. It can help **catch** attention and create **a welcoming impression**, but what still decides is mainly **what you sell**, **to whom** and **how well** it all works together.

What we are telling the customer

Orange can say, for example

“Come closer.” “It's pleasant here.” “You can try it.” “It's simple.”

- **Friendliness and warmth.** It does not feel as serious as red. It invites conversation.
- **Energy and joy.** It suits where you want to awaken appetite and enthusiasm.
- **Creativity.** It is linked with ideas, playfulness and unconventionality.
- **Visibility.** It is easily visible, and that is why it is used in safety.
- **Approachability.** It is often credited with accessibility and friendliness. Not everywhere and always, but brands use it when they want to seem relaxed.

Depending on the shade, though, it can also feel different. A rich orange is **more active** and **louder**, terracotta feels **earthy and crafted**, peach and apricot **warm and soft**, saffron **warming and festive**.

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Simple tips

As a second colour

It works brilliantly as an accent next to a calm base (blue, grey, cream). It is the second button, not the main alarm.

Shade by role

Rich for energy and action, peach and apricot for warmth, terracotta for craft and earthiness, saffron for warming festivity.

Cultural context

In Ireland orange can recall political division, in India saffron means spiritual renunciation, in the Netherlands it is used to celebrate. Before you set out into the world, find out what orange means with you and with them.

Colour blindness

About 1 in 12 men has trouble telling red and green apart. Do not use these two colours as the only difference between two things.

Not the whole website

Large rich orange areas tire and put customers off.

Legibility

White text on orange often lacks enough contrast. Try dark lettering or a darker shade.

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Professions where it is a Yes

Café, bistro, baking and a shared table

Orange can support a story of warmth, food and hospitality. Try ceramics, packaging or part of the lettering. For a small quiet café I would choose a different form than for fast food. A guest may want to sit for a while and does not need to feel from the packaging that they have to be at the next stop within three minutes.

Ceramics, craft and natural materials

Terracotta or rust can accompany clay, wood, textiles and handwork well. **Why.** The shade can connect to the real material and the experience of it, you do not have to invent a story the product does not have at all. But let the work itself stand out. When an orange website swallows all the photographs of ceramics, the colour has got a bit too excited about its own exhibition.

Movement, dance, leisure and social events

A stronger orange can be suitable where you want to invite people to an activity, a meeting and an informal atmosphere. Give it a clear task on the poster. One motif, name or important piece of information. If you highlight everything, the organiser will be loud even on paper.

Body care and personal projects

A soft apricot can be pleasant for a brand that wants to feel personal and warming. Try it next to real photographs and natural materials. But watch whether the result captures your work. If you offer deep stillness, a radiant orange website full of movement may promise a different experience.

Professions where it is a No

This is not a ban for whole fields. What decides is the interplay of colour, text, photographs and setting.

- **Accompaniment in grief and crisis help.** A pronounced cheerfulness can feel out of place towards what a woman comes with. A soft warm detail may work better than a whole radiant page.
- **A space meant for deep rest.** I would first test large rich areas. If they keep drawing attention over and over, they can go against the intended impression of stillness.
- **A brand based on discretion and quiet elegance.** A sharp orange can drown out the subtlety of the offer. A muted shade or a small accent may be more precise.
- **A place where orange already marks an operational notice.** More orange decoration can visually drown an important signal.

Give important information clearly legible dark text.

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Before you send it out into the world

Show the design to a woman who does not know your offer, and ask “What would you expect from such a place or service?” **Is the offer visible, or mainly the orange?** Her answer may tell you more than the general rule that orange means joy.

A question for you

“What should your customer feel first when she looks at your website?”

Examples from the market

You know orange from shops, adverts and the street. Here are **a few examples** that show what it can do.

- **Hermès (luxury fashion)**
  According to a story the company itself tells, Hermès switched to orange boxes in 1942 because its usual packaging was not available. The story comes from the company and has not been independently verified. The colour, though, became its trademark because the company held to it long and consistently.

- **Orange (telecommunications)**
  The telecommunications brand Orange was created in Great Britain on 28 April 1994 in cooperation with Hans Snook and the agency Wolff Olins. It was meant to feel welcoming, simple and friendly. The logo deliberately does not look like a fruit. Since 2013 the original France Télécom has also been called by that name.

- **easyJet (airline)**
  The founder Stelios wanted a colour the airline would “own”. He chose orange (Pantone 021C, today “easyOrange”), which the company has as a trademark. The planes are recognisable from afar.

- **Nickelodeon (children's television)**
  The children's channel has used orange and white since 1984. The orange “splat” came only around 2003 and originally referred to the slime gags from the Canadian show *You Can't Do That on Television*.

What they have in common is that orange carries a simple message. **Close, visible, playful.** And it is mostly not everywhere, only where it is meant to stand out.

Colours in business are not law. Studies are mixed and a lot depends on context, on customers and on how consistent the brand is. Take it as an idea to test, not as a rule. The brand examples are publicly known and the facts about them come from public sources; for Hermès it is the company's own story.

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Different colour combinations

Orange + red

How it feels

Hot, lively, bold. Red adds strength and orange warms; together they are like glowing embers.

When it suits

When you want **energy and courage**.

Specific shades



bright orange + red
loud



terracotta + wine
deep and warm



apricot + scarlet
soft



pumpkin + crimson
autumnal



peach + coral
gentle and playful

In practice

An orange scarf and **red lipstick**. Terracotta and wine in a living room.

Watch out

Large areas of both can feel **loud** and tiring.

Orange + yellow

How it feels

Sunny, light, joyful. Yellow brightens orange; like the sun over a field.

When it suits

When you want a **festive, sunny** mood or to support **creativity**.

Specific shades



orange + lemon
sunny



pumpkin + mustard
autumnal



apricot + butter
soft



amber + golden
festive



terracotta + ochre
earthy

In practice

A yellow and an orange cushion. A kitchen in warm tones.

Watch out

Rich orange + rich yellow can recall **fast food** or **warning graphics**.

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Orange + green

How it feels

Playful and natural. A garden or an autumn wood; green calms orange.

When it suits

When you want to join **warmth** with a **natural feel**.

Specific shades


pumpkin + olive
naturally


terracotta + sage
gentle and earthy


orange + dark green
rich


apricot + mint
fresh


rust + moss
woodland

In practice

Oranges and leaves. A green coat and an orange scarf.

Watch out

A sharp green + a sharp orange can feel **very loud**, even childish.

Orange + blue

How it feels

Spark and calm at once. Blue is the counterpart of orange on the colour wheel. The strongest contrast of warm and cool.

When it suits

When you want orange to **stand out**.

Specific shades


orange + cobalt
striking


terracotta + denim
earthy and calm


apricot + light blue
gentle


pumpkin + petrol
deep


peach + grey-blue
quiet

In practice

An orange accessory in a blue room. Blue jeans and an orange jumper.

Watch out

Mixed together they **turn brown**. Side by side both can strengthen each other, give one the main role.

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Orange + indigo

How it feels

Dramatic and evening-like. Orange next to a deep blue-violet feels like the setting sun in the evening sky.

When it suits

When you want **warmth in the dark** and dramatic beauty.

Specific shades



orange + indigo
dramatic



amber + midnight blue
evening-like



terracotta + navy
deep



apricot + ink
gentle on dark



rust + plum blue
festive

In practice

An indigo wall with an orange lamp. Evening lighting.

Watch out

Many dark areas and a rich orange can feel **heavy**; give indigo more room.

Orange + violet

How it feels

Playful and mysterious. A rich, exotic pair.

When it suits

When you want a feeling of **exoticism** and luxury.

Specific shades



orange + purple
boldly



peach + lavender
tenderly



terracotta + plum
deeply



mandarin + amethyst
playfully



apricot + lilac
gently

In practice

A violet scarf and an orange bag. A violet wall and orange accessories.

Watch out

Rich orange + rich violet is **very loud**; tone one down.

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Orange + pink

How it feels

Tender and warm. Pink is red diluted with white; with orange it gives peach, coral and apricot.

When it suits

When you want **tenderness and warmth**.

Specific shades


peach + powder
tenderly


coral + pale pink
playfully


orange + fuchsia
boldly


terracotta + dusty pink
earthy and gentle


salmon + apricot
tenderly

In practice

Coral and peach in a bedroom. A pink jumper and an orange scarf.

Watch out

Two sweet colours can be **too sweet**; add cream or wood.

Orange + grey

How it feels

Calm and modern. Grey calms orange and lets it stand out.

When it suits

When you want a **modern, restrained** look.

Specific shades


orange + anthracite
modern


terracotta + light grey
calm


apricot + dove
gentle


pumpkin + slate
elegant


peach + silver-grey
quiet

In practice

A grey sofa and an orange cushion. A grey coat and an orange hat.

Watch out

Grey + rich orange can recall **sports or work gear**.

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Orange + brown

How it feels

Earthy and homely. Brown grounds and warms orange.

When it suits

When you want **autumn warmth** and natural materials.

Specific shades


orange + chocolate
richly


apricot + caramel
softly


terracotta + dark wood
earthy


pumpkin + chestnut
autumnal


peach + beige
gently

In practice

A wooden table and orange ceramics. A leather jacket and an orange scarf.

Watch out

Two earthy colours can be **heavy**; add a light cream.

Orange + white

How it feels

Clean and fresh. White lifts orange up.

When it suits

When you want **lightness** and space.

Specific shades


orange + pure white
fresh


terracotta + cream
soft


apricot + milky
quiet


pumpkin + ivory
autumnal


rust + linen
natural

In practice

A white kitchen with orange ceramics. A white shirt and an orange scarf.

Watch out

Pure white + bright orange can be **sharp**; cream is gentler.

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Orange + black

How it feels

Strong and graphic. Black sets orange off; warmth becomes a striking contrast.

When it suits

When you want a **striking** or **festive** impression.

Specific shades


orange + black
striking


terracotta + charcoal
elegant


apricot + graphite
gentle


pumpkin + anthracite
autumnal


saffron + black
festive

In practice

A black dress and an orange handbag. Black furniture with a terracotta detail.

Watch out

If you do not want an impression of **Halloween** or sports kit, try only a little of it.

Orange + gold

How it feels

Sunset. Orange warms gold and gold softens orange. Together they feel warming and playful.

When it suits

When you want **warmth and light**.

Specific shades


orange + gold
radiantly


terracotta + antique gold
warmly


apricot + champagne
playfully


pumpkin + rich gold
richly


rust + matt gold
earthy

In practice

An orange jumper and a gold chain. An orange cushion and a gold lamp.

Watch out

Too many warm colours side by side tire. Try **adding green**.

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A SIMPLE RULE

- When you want to **soften** orange, add **white**, **cream**, **peach** or **grey**.
- When you want to **ground** it, add **brown**, **terracotta**, **olive** or **natural materials**.
- When you want to **make it stand out**, add **blue**, **turquoise**, **indigo** or **black**.
- When you want to **cool it**, **blue**, **green** or **grey** will help.

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